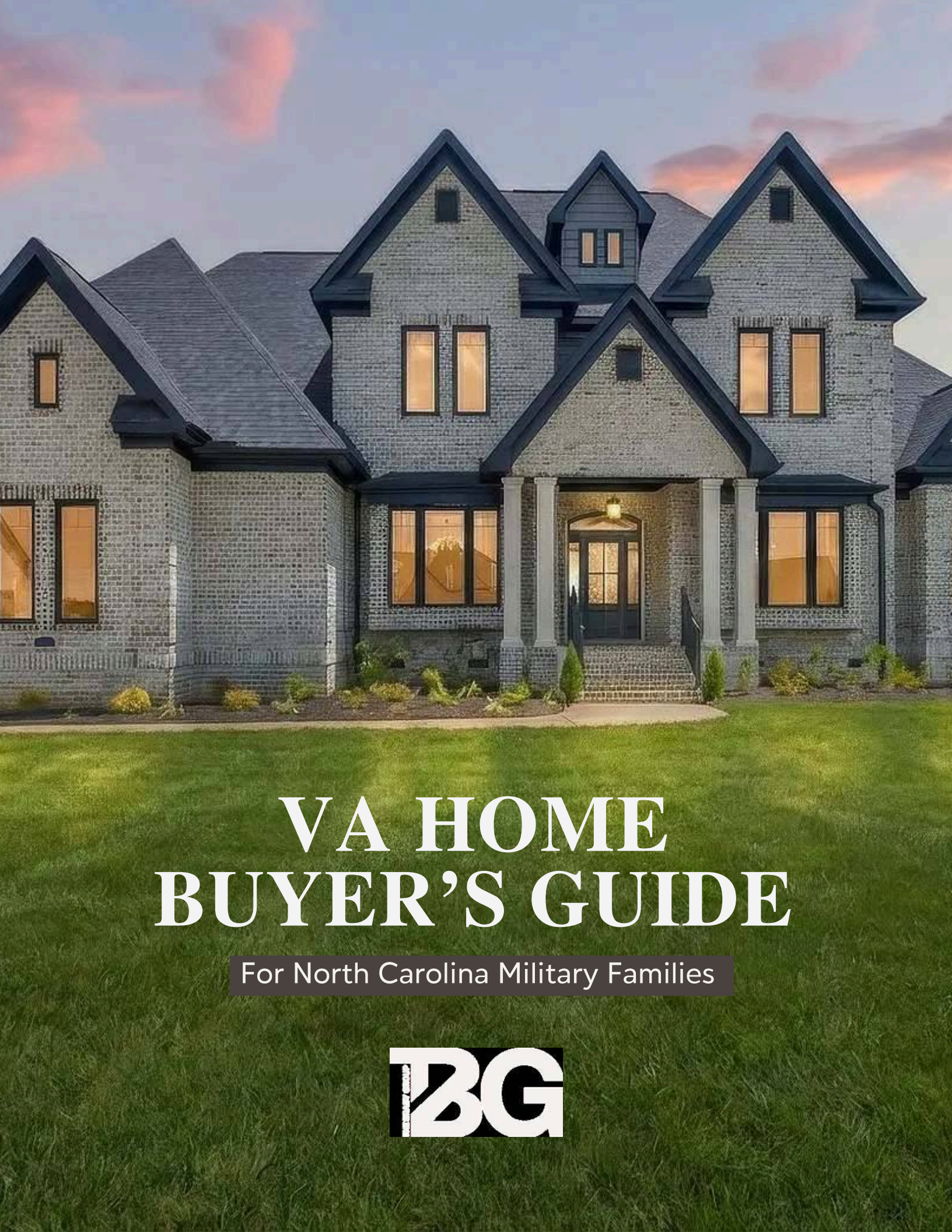
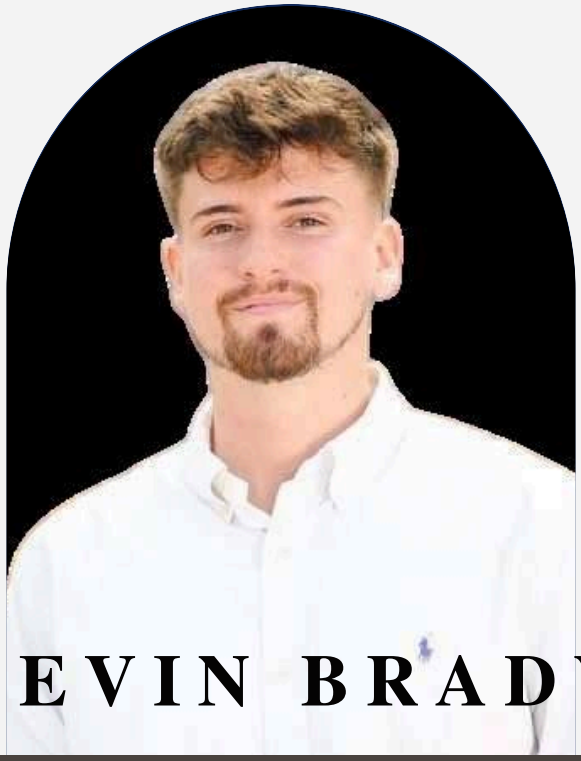


VA HOME BUYER'S GUIDE

For North Carolina Military Families

BG



DEVIN BRADY

Your North Carolina VA Home Buying Resource

Buying a home while serving, transitioning, relocating, or using your VA benefit can feel overwhelming, especially when you are balancing orders, timelines, family needs, and the realities of a new market. My role is to help you understand the process, protect your interests, and guide you through each step with clear communication and local North Carolina market knowledge.

Whether you are buying near Fort Bragg, Seymour Johnson Air Force Base, Camp Lejeune, or MCAS Cherry Point, this guide will walk you through the VA loan process, North Carolina contract considerations, and the key decisions to expect from pre-approval to closing.

LET'S CONNECT

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North Carolina Military Installations

North Carolina is one of the most military-connected states in the country, with major installations serving Army, Air Force, Marine Corps, Navy, and Coast Guard families. The key installations to feature in this VA Buyer Guide are:

01 **Fort Bragg**

Formerly Fort Liberty, the installation was renamed Fort Bragg again in 2025, now honoring World War II soldier Pfc. Roland L. Bragg.

02 **Seymour Johnson Air Force Base**

Located in Goldsboro, this is a major Air Force installation serving airmen and military families in eastern North Carolina.

03 **Marine Corps Base Camp Lejeune**

Located near Jacksonville, Camp Lejeune supports several Marine Corps commands and is one of the largest Marine Corps installations on the East Coast.

04 **Marine Corps Air Station Cherry Point**

Located near Havelock and New Bern, MCAS Cherry Point is a major Marine Corps aviation installation in eastern North Carolina.

What is a VA Loan?

VA LOAN BASICS

A VA loan is a mortgage benefit available to eligible Veterans, active-duty service members, certain members of the National Guard and Reserve, and eligible surviving spouses. VA-backed home loans are made by private lenders, but the Department of Veterans Affairs guarantees a portion of the loan, which helps qualified buyers access strong financing terms. VA describes the program as a benefit that helps eligible borrowers buy, build, repair, retain, or adapt a home for their own personal occupancy.



KEY IDEA

A VA loan is not a grant or free house. It is a powerful mortgage benefit that can make homeownership more accessible, especially because it may allow eligible buyers to purchase with no down payment and no monthly mortgage insurance.



Who Qualifies?

DO YOU QUALIFY FOR A VA LOAN?

You may be eligible for a VA-backed home loan if you meet VA service requirements and can obtain a Certificate of Eligibility, often called a COE. VA eligibility may apply to:

- Veterans
- Active-duty service members
- National Guard members
- Reserve members
- Certain eligible surviving spouses

To use a VA-backed home loan, buyers must also meet VA and lender requirements for credit, income, and occupancy. VA notes that buyers need to meet requirements from both VA and the lender.

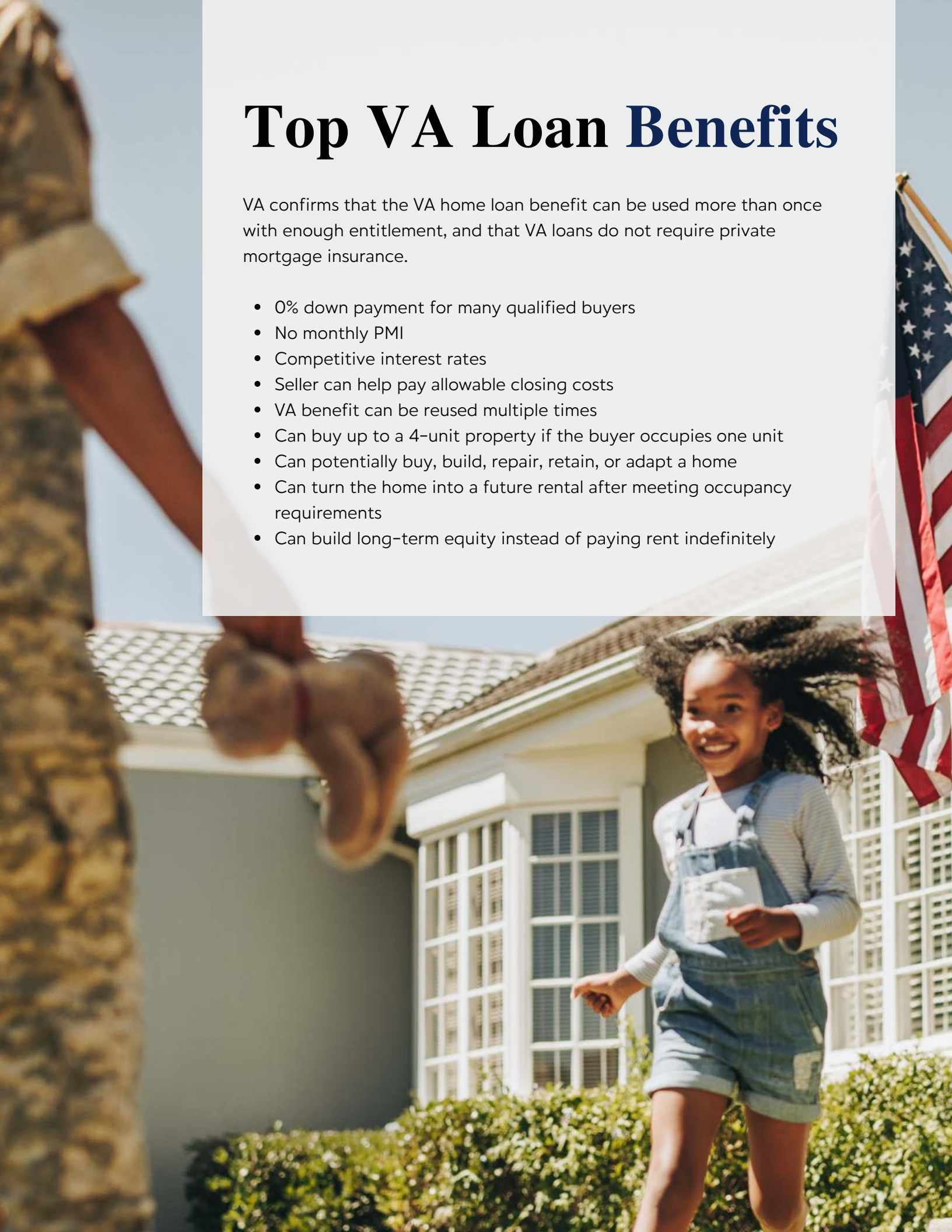
DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- **Certificate of Eligibility**
- **Photo ID**
- **Pay stubs or LES**
- **W-2s or tax returns**
- **Bank statements**
- **Debt and asset information**
- **DD214, when applicable**
- **Additional income documentation, when applicable**

Top VA Loan Benefits

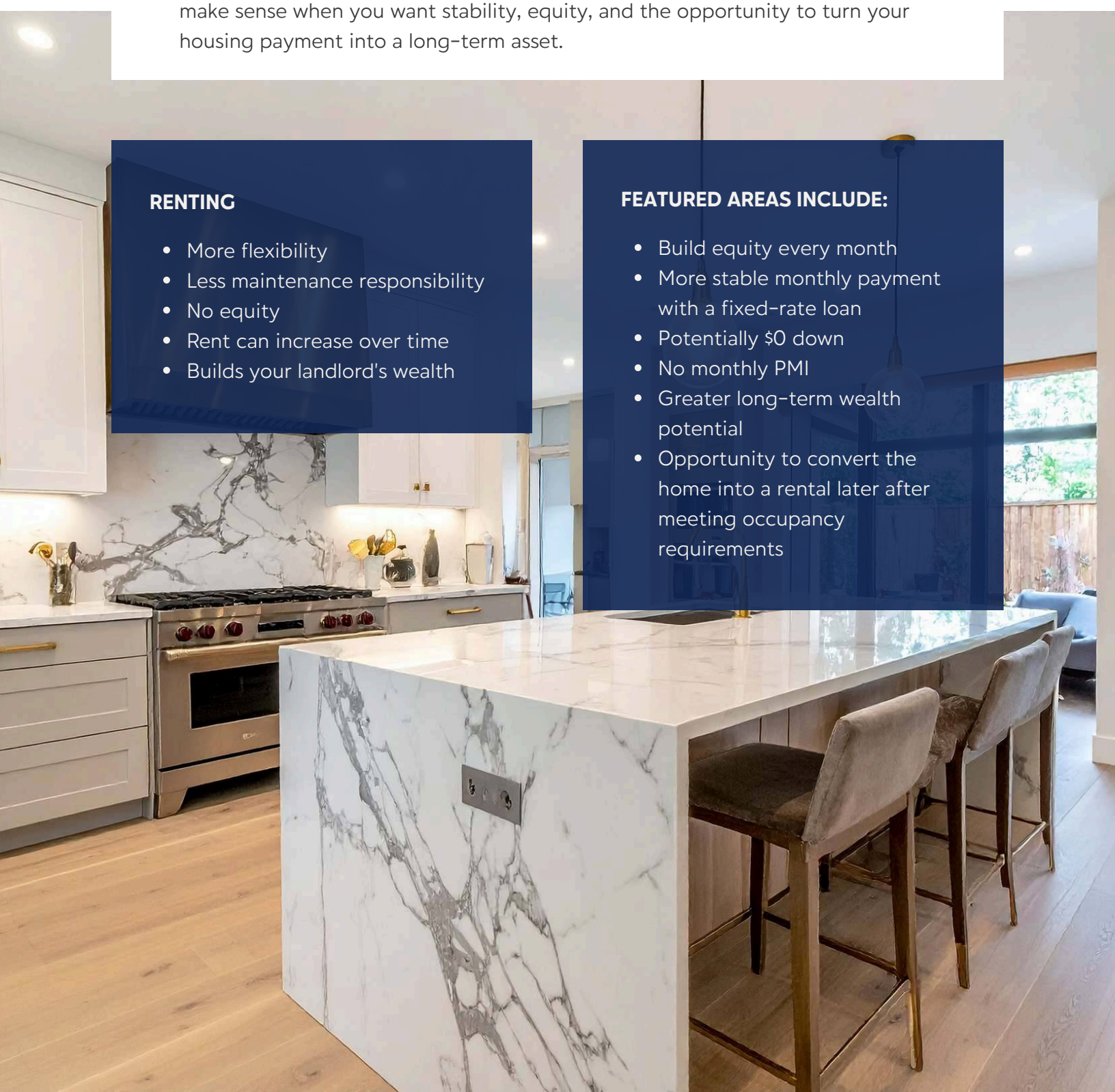
VA confirms that the VA home loan benefit can be used more than once with enough entitlement, and that VA loans do not require private mortgage insurance.

- 0% down payment for many qualified buyers
- No monthly PMI
- Competitive interest rates
- Seller can help pay allowable closing costs
- VA benefit can be reused multiple times
- Can buy up to a 4-unit property if the buyer occupies one unit
- Can potentially buy, build, repair, retain, or adapt a home
- Can turn the home into a future rental after meeting occupancy requirements
- Can build long-term equity instead of paying rent indefinitely



Renting vs. Buying With A VA Loan

Renting may make sense for short timelines or uncertain plans. Buying can make sense when you want stability, equity, and the opportunity to turn your housing payment into a long-term asset.



RENTING

- More flexibility
- Less maintenance responsibility
- No equity
- Rent can increase over time
- Builds your landlord's wealth

FEATURED AREAS INCLUDE:

- Build equity every month
- More stable monthly payment with a fixed-rate loan
- Potentially $0 down
- No monthly PMI
- Greater long-term wealth potential
- Opportunity to convert the home into a rental later after meeting occupancy requirements



The VA Buying Process

STEP 1

GET PRE-APPROVED

- Meet with a lender
- Prepare your credit
- Set a budget

STEP 2

MEET WITH YOUR AGENT

- Discuss budget
- Research area neighborhoods
- Set wants & needs

STEP 3

FIND YOUR HOME

- Tour homes
- Adjust criteria if necessary

STEP 4

MAKE AN OFFER

- Research comps in the area
- Work with your realtor to set up the best offer
- Negotiations may occur

STEP 5

OFFER SIGNED

- All negotiations are finished
- Both parties have signed contract

STEP 6

INSPECTIONS

- Professional inspects the property
- Discovers issues that may need to be worked into the purchase agreement
- Negotiate repairs

STEP 7

APPRAISAL

- Professional ensures the property is worth the loan and purchase price you agreed to pay

STEP 8

TITLE COMMITMENT

- The title company will send you a title insurance policy for the property after closing

STEP 9

DOCUMENTS TO LENDER

- Make sure all requested docs are sent to your lender prior to closing

STEP 10

CLOSING

- Final walk-through
- Sign closing documents
- Receive your keys

The VA Homebuying Process

1. MEET WITH YOUR REAL ESTATE AGENT
2. GET VA PRE-APPROVED
3. CONFIRM YOUR CERTIFICATE OF ELIGIBILITY
4. SET YOUR BUDGET AND MONTHLY PAYMENT COMFORT ZONE
5. START HOME SHOPPING
6. MAKE A STRONG VA OFFER
7. GO UNDER CONTRACT
8. COMPLETE DUE DILIGENCE, INSPECTIONS, AND NEGOTIATIONS
9. VA APPRAISAL IS ORDERED
10. FINAL UNDERWRITING, CLOSING DISCLOSURE, AND CLOSING DAY





Step 1:
Meet With Your Agent

Finding the Right Agent

Buying with a VA loan is not complicated when the process is handled correctly, but it does require an agent who understands VA offers, appraisals, property condition expectations, local timelines, and North Carolina contract terms

Your agent helps you:

- Narrow homes based on your budget, commute, school needs, and duty station
- Understand the local market near North Carolina military installations
- Structure a competitive VA offer
- Coordinate inspections, appraisal timelines, and lender communication
- Navigate North Carolina due diligence and earnest money
- Protect your interests from contract to closing

NORTH CAROLINA NOTE: The offer strategy matters because North Carolina commonly uses both a due diligence fee and earnest money deposit. These are separate from your VA loan benefit.

Step 2:
Get Pre-Approved

VA Pre-Approval Process

Before touring homes seriously, speak with a VA-experienced lender. A strong pre-approval helps you understand your budget, estimated monthly payment, closing costs, funding fee, and how your VA entitlement applies.

Your lender will typically review:

- Credit history
- Income
- Debts
- Assets
- Employment
- Certificate of Eligibility
- Debt-to-income ratio
- Residual income
- Occupancy plan

VA itself does not set one universal minimum credit score, but lenders may set their own credit requirements. VA also states that lenders determine the loan amount a borrower can afford based on factors like credit history, income, debts, and assets.





Credit & Income Requirements

VA loans are flexible, but they are not automatic approvals. Your lender will review your ability to repay the mortgage and may have its own underwriting standards.

Credit considerations:

- Make payments on time
- Avoid opening new credit
- Avoid large purchases before closing
- Do not change jobs without speaking to your lender
- Keep credit card balances manageable
- Respond quickly to lender document requests

Income considerations:

- Base pay
- BAH
- BAS
- Civilian employment income
- Retirement income
- Disability income, when applicable
- Spouse income, when applicable
- Bonus, overtime, or part-time income, if documented and accepted by the lender

Important:

Your pre-approval should be based on your real budget, not just the maximum amount you can technically borrow.



Step 4:
Make a VA Offer

When you find the right home, your offer should be written to protect you while also being attractive to the seller.

A VA offer may include:

- Purchase price
- Due diligence fee
- Earnest money deposit
- Due diligence period
- Closing date
- Seller-paid closing cost request
- Personal property or appliances
- Repair expectations
- VA financing terms
- VA amendatory clause, when required

Seller-paid closing costs

Sellers may help with certain buyer costs, but VA rules place limits on some seller concessions. VA states that seller concessions or seller contributions are capped at 4% of the reasonable value in certain contexts.

North Carolina Due Diligence & Earnest Money

North Carolina is different from many other states because buyers often negotiate both a due diligence fee and earnest money.

Due Diligence Fee

- Paid directly to the seller
- Negotiated between buyer and seller
- Usually due shortly after contract acceptance
- Generally nonrefundable except in rare circumstances
- Gives the buyer the right to investigate the property during the due diligence period

The North Carolina Real Estate Commission explains that, as a general rule, the due diligence fee is paid to the seller at contract formation and is nonrefundable except in rare circumstances.

Earnest Money Deposit

- Usually held in escrow or trust
- Shows good faith
- Typically credited toward closing if the buyer closes
- May be refundable if the buyer terminates properly during the due diligence period
- May be at risk if the buyer terminates after the due diligence period without a valid contract reason



VA buyer note:

Even with 0% down financing, buyers may still need funds for due diligence, earnest money, inspections, appraisal, closing costs, and moving expenses.



VA Appraisal vs. Home Inspection

VA Appraisal

- Required by VA
- Ordered by the lender
- Completed by a VA-approved appraiser
- Reviews value and basic property standards
- Helps confirm the home is safe, sound, sanitary, and worth the purchase price

Home Inspection

- Optional, but strongly recommended
- Ordered by the buyer
- Completed by a licensed or qualified home inspector
- Reviews the home's condition in more detail
- Helps buyers understand repairs, safety concerns, systems, and long-term maintenance

VA's buyer guide states that the VA appraisal is mandatory for purchase loans and that a VA-approved appraiser determines a reasonable value.

Step 5: Inspections & Repair Negotiations

During the due diligence period, you can inspect the home and decide whether to move forward, ask for repairs, request seller credits, or terminate under the terms of the contract.

Common inspections may include:

- General home inspection
- Termite or wood-destroying insect inspection
- HVAC inspection
- Roof inspection
- Septic inspection
- Well inspection
- Structural inspection
- Radon test
- Survey, when needed

North Carolina VA note:

North Carolina is listed by VA as a state where wood-destroying insect information is required. VA's local requirements page says wood-destroying insect information is required for the entire state when listed.



VA Closing Costs

Common costs may include:

- Lender fees
- Appraisal fee
- Credit report fee
- Title search
- Title insurance
- Recording fees
- Attorney fees
- Prepaid taxes and insurance
- Homeowners insurance
- HOA dues or transfer fees, if applicable
- VA funding fee, unless exempt
- Inspection costs
- Survey, if needed

The VA funding fee is a one-time fee on many VA-backed or VA direct home loans. VA explains that the funding fee can be paid at closing or financed into the loan, and that it helps lower the cost of the program because VA loans do not require down payments or monthly mortgage insurance.







Buying New Construction With a VA Loan

A VA loan can be used for new construction when the builder, lender, property, and loan structure meet VA and lender requirements.

New construction considerations:

- Builder approval
- Plans and specifications
- VA appraisal based on plans and specs
- Construction timeline
- Certificate of occupancy
- Final inspection
- Interest rate lock
- Closing date expectations
- Builder incentives
- Warranty coverage

Important: Not every lender offers VA construction or one-time close construction loans, so buyers should confirm this early.



VA One-Time Close Construction Loan

A VA One-Time Close, also called a single-close construction loan, can combine the construction loan and permanent mortgage into one loan. This can allow eligible buyers to finance the land, construction, and permanent mortgage together instead of closing on separate loans.

Benefits may include:

- One loan process
- One closing
- Potentially 0% down for eligible buyers
- Ability to build and customize your own home
- Choose floor plan, finishes, and features
- Move into a brand-new home built around your needs

VA's buyer guide describes a one-time close construction loan as a loan used to close both the construction loan and permanent financing at the same time, with final terms modified to permanent terms at the conclusion of construction.



Build Equity & Future Rental Potential

Your VA Loan Can Support Long-Term Wealth

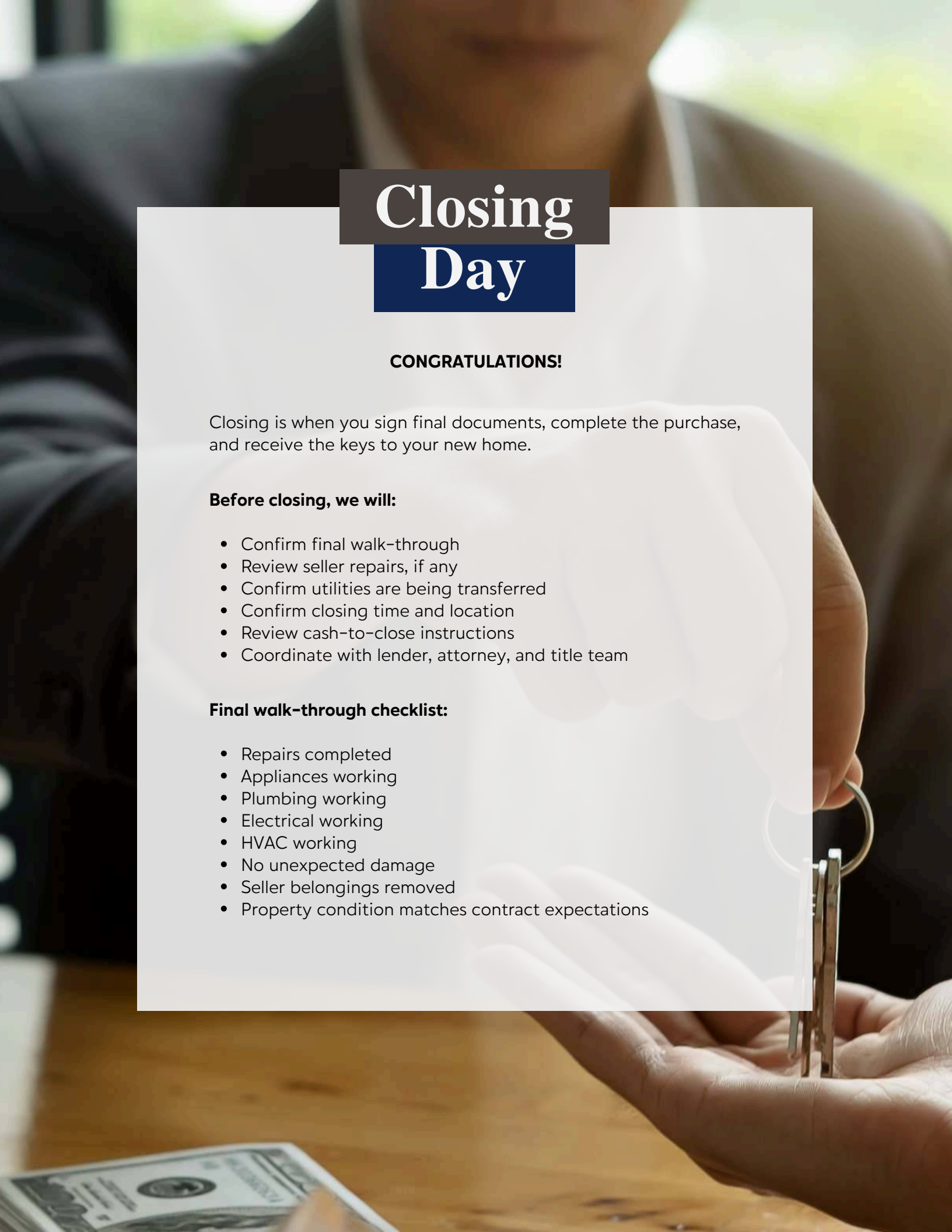
A VA loan is not just about buying a home today. Used strategically, it can help build long-term equity and future flexibility.

Potential long-term benefits:

- Build equity as you pay down the loan
- Benefit from possible appreciation
- Create payment stability with a fixed-rate mortgage
- Convert the home into a rental later after meeting occupancy requirements
- Use the VA loan benefit again in the future if eligible and entitlement allows
- Buy up to a 4-unit property when you occupy one unit

Military buyer note:

- For PCS-heavy families, rental potential can matter. A home that works for your life today may also become an asset later.



Closing Day

CONGRATULATIONS!

Closing is when you sign final documents, complete the purchase, and receive the keys to your new home.

Before closing, we will:

- Confirm final walk-through
- Review seller repairs, if any
- Confirm utilities are being transferred
- Confirm closing time and location
- Review cash-to-close instructions
- Coordinate with lender, attorney, and title team

Final walk-through checklist:

- Repairs completed
- Appliances working
- Plumbing working
- Electrical working
- HVAC working
- No unexpected damage
- Seller belongings removed
- Property condition matches contract expectations

Moving Checklist

4 Weeks Before Move

- Schedule movers or rental truck
- Start decluttering
- Collect important documents
- Begin packing non-essentials
- Notify landlord, if renting
- Research utility providers

3 Weeks Before Move

- Confirm closing timeline
- Get homeowners insurance quotes
- Arrange school records, if needed
- Start address change list
- Schedule base, work, or family logistics

2 Weeks Before Move

- Transfer utilities
- Pack room by room
- Confirm moving arrangements
- Update mailing address
- Prepare funds needed for closing

1 Week Before Move

- Confirm final walk-through
- Confirm closing appointment
- Pack essentials bag
- Clean current home
- Confirm delivery date and directions
- Keep IDs, documents, chargers, medications, and uniforms accessible



Final Tips for VA Buyers in North Carolina



SMART VA BUYER TIPS

- Get pre-approved before touring homes
- Work with a VA-experienced lender
- Understand due diligence before making an offer
- Budget for inspections and closing costs
- Do not skip a home inspection
- Remember that VA appraisal and inspection are different
- Keep your lender updated on any financial changes
- Ask about seller-paid closing costs when appropriate
- Consider resale and rental potential
- Choose the home that fits your life, not just your loan approval amount



Ready to Buy With Your VA Benefit?

Your VA loan is an earned benefit. Whether you are buying your first home, relocating to North Carolina, building new construction, or planning for long-term wealth, the right guidance can make the process smoother and less stressful.

let's connect!

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